

DAY 18: AVOID BIG HOSPITAL BILLS

I can't say I have a ton of experience with hospitals, which I guess is not only a good thing, it also means I can count on one hand how many times either Joseph or I have been in one. Between the two of us, we've experienced one appendectomy, one outpatient surgery, and a couple of broken bones, but other than that, nothing too major. I know—we're very lucky!

You would think our medical bills would reflect this, but instead, hospitals like to charge us more per visit than a week at a ritzy condo. If you had seen any of our local facilities at the time, you would know that description does not fit...*at all*.

Unfortunately, hospitals charge for anything and everything these days, from a two-minute visit to a small dose of Advil. Even the doctor who sees you can charge you in addition to what the hospital does. I understand that everyone should get paid for their time, but this type of price gouging is absolutely ridiculous. It's no wonder we quickly find ourselves buried under a huge medical and financial mess.

In fact, just this past summer, we experienced our first cancer scare (which turned out to be nothing, thankfully!), but it did mean we had a lot more mail from specialists and surgeons than we were used to. The cost to get everything resolved completely depleted our Emergency Fund and then some, and a few months later, I was still paying off all the expenses we incurred.

While it's something I would never want to go through again, this experience showed me just how much a small problem can escalate into a major cost. That means it's even more important to cut where we can, and prevent big hospital bills in the future. These five tips will show you exactly how and where to start:

1. TRY A WALK-IN CLINIC